“People only feel sorry for me.”

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Where it often comes from

Pity can feel patronizing: a head tilt, extra helpfulness, lowered expectations. Over time, we may shut out all kindness to avoid being pitied.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus had compassion and also treated people as full persons: “Do you want to get well?” (John 5:6), He asked, and He said, “Get up, pick up your mat, and walk.” Peter said to the lame man, “What I have I give you,” and then took him by the right hand. Compassion and respect go together. Not everyone gets it right, but many act from love. “Rejoice with those who rejoice; weep with those who weep.” You can invite people to relate as equals.

> *“But Peter said, ‘Silver or gold I do not have, but what I have I give you: In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, get up and walk!’”* (Acts 3:6).

Also see

> “When Jesus saw him lying there and realized that he had spent a long time in this condition, He asked him, ‘Do you want to get well?’” (John 5:6).

> “Rejoice with those who rejoice; weep with those who weep” (Romans 12:15).

> “For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin” (Hebrews 4:15).

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” (Galatians 6:2).

Common self-statements

- They see me as a charity case.
- They think I am pathetic.
- Nobody respects me.
- Kindness is just pity.
- They do not see me.
- I do not want sympathy.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing people either respect me or pity me.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that people will see only my condition.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling pitied and concluding I am not respected.
- Mind reading: Calling myself a charity case.

Challenging questions

- Who treats me as an equal?
- What do I want people to see?
- How can I invite a different kind of relationship?

- What do I give back in friendship?
- What did Jesus' and Peter's example show about compassion and respect?
- What is one conversation where I could be more direct?

Truth summary

> People's kindness can come from love, and I can invite respect by sharing what I want them to see. Jesus shows compassion that respects, and I can look for friendships of equals.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Friendship
- Pride
- Humility
- Love, For Others
- Self-Esteem, Low

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "People only feel sorry for me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"People only feel sorry for me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who treats me as an equal?
- ☐ What do I want people to see?
- ☐ How can I invite a different kind of relationship?
- ☐ What do I give back in friendship?
- ☐ What did Jesus' and Peter's example show about compassion and respect?
- ☐ What is one conversation where I could be more direct?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Compassion and respect go together.
- ☐ Jesus treated people as whole persons.
- ☐ I can invite respect.
- ☐ I give as well as receive.
- ☐ Many act from love.
- ☐ I can speak up.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Acts 3:6
  "But Peter said, 'Silver or gold I do not have, but what I have I give you: In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, get up and walk!'"
- ☐ John 5:6
  "When Jesus saw him lying there and realized that he had spent a long time in this condition, He asked him, 'Do you want to get well?'"
- ☐ Romans 12:15
  "Rejoice with those who rejoice; weep with those who weep."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Seen and respected: Each week, note one interaction where you felt respected.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Acts 3:6 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Compassion and respect go together.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Friendship" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] List respectful people. Write who treats you as an equal.
- [ ] Say what you want. Tell a friend how to help.
- [ ] Give back. Encourage, pray for, or listen to others.
- [ ] Read John 5:1–9. Notice Jesus' question.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "People only feel sorry for me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Seen and respected
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~People only feel sorry for me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I want to be seen, not pitied. Teach me to receive kindness and invite respect, and send friends who see all of me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.